Western MA Per Pupil Expenditure Report

Inflation Addendum — DRAFT, October 18, 2026

The main report compares per-pupil expenditure (PPE) in nominal dollars. Over FY2009–FY2025, prices rose too: 44% by the CPI-U for the Northeast (2.3% a year) and 54% by the federal price index for state and local government purchases (2.7% a year). This addendum restates the report's PPE levels and growth rates against both.

Western MA PPE grew 4.0% a year in nominal terms. After Northeast consumer inflation, that is 1.7% a year; after state and local government inflation, 1.2% a year.

Which price index

CPI-U Northeast measures what households in the region pay for goods and services. It answers the taxpayer's question: has school spending outpaced the cost of living? **The state and local government deflator** (BEA, NIPA Table 1.1.9) measures the prices state and local governments pay, mostly for labor. It answers the budget's question: has spending outpaced the cost of what schools buy? The Commonwealth uses it to inflate the Chapter 70 foundation budget, with a 4.5% annual cap (M.G.L. c.70, s.2). Each index is averaged over the July–June fiscal year, the same period as DESE's school year.

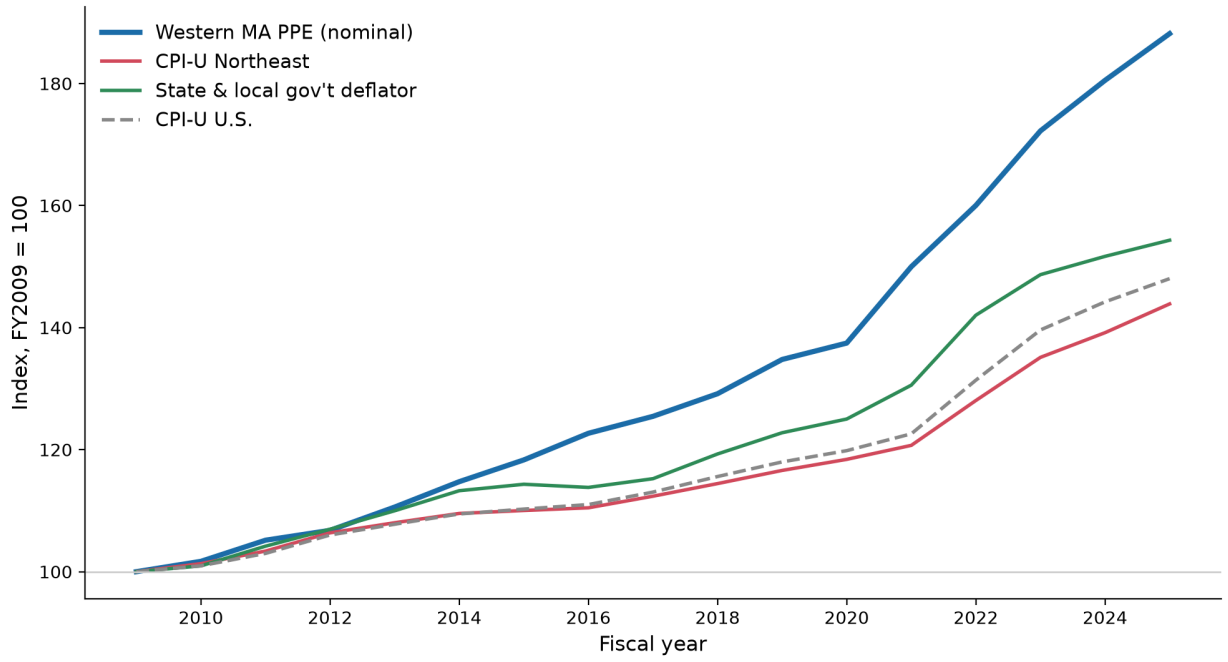


Figure 1. Western MA PPE and price indexes, FY2009 = 100.

PPE growth, nominal and real, FY2009–FY2025

Cohort/District	FY2009 $/pupil	FY2009 in FY2025 $	FY2025 $/pupil	Nominal 16y	Real 16y (CPI-NE)	Real 16y (S&L; defl.)	Real 10y (CPI-NE)	Real 5y (CPI-NE)
Western MA (all, excl. Springfield)	$12,210	$17,568	$22,976	+4.0%	+1.7%	+1.2%	+2.0%	+2.4%
Western MA Tiny (8)	$13,941	$20,058	$31,804	+5.3%	+2.9%	+2.5%	+3.3%	+6.3%
Western MA Small (25)	$12,418	$17,867	$25,462	+4.6%	+2.2%	+1.8%	+2.5%	+2.7%
Western MA Medium (16)	$13,220	$19,021	$25,059	+4.1%	+1.7%	+1.3%	+2.1%	+2.4%
Western MA Large (15)	$11,774	$16,941	$21,765	+3.9%	+1.6%	+1.1%	+1.8%	+2.4%
Springfield (1)	$14,608	$21,018	$26,053	+3.7%	+1.4%	+0.9%	+2.8%	+4.5%
Amherst-Pelham Regional	$16,211	$23,324	$27,899	+3.5%	+1.1%	+0.7%	+0.8%	+1.1%
Amherst	$16,029	$23,062	$29,984	+4.0%	+1.7%	+1.2%	+1.1%	+0.7%
Leverett	$15,156	$21,806	$23,732	+2.8%	+0.5%	+0.1%	-0.6%	+0.5%
Pelham	$14,733	$21,198	$21,573	+2.4%	+0.1%	-0.3%	-0.7%	-1.2%
Shutesbury	$14,011	$20,159	$27,389	+4.3%	+1.9%	+1.5%	+3.0%	-0.6%

Growth rates are compound annual rates. Real rates divide each year's PPE by the index for that fiscal year. Cohort averages are weighted by in-district FTE, with cohort membership set by FY2025 enrollment as in the main report; the number of districts is in parentheses.

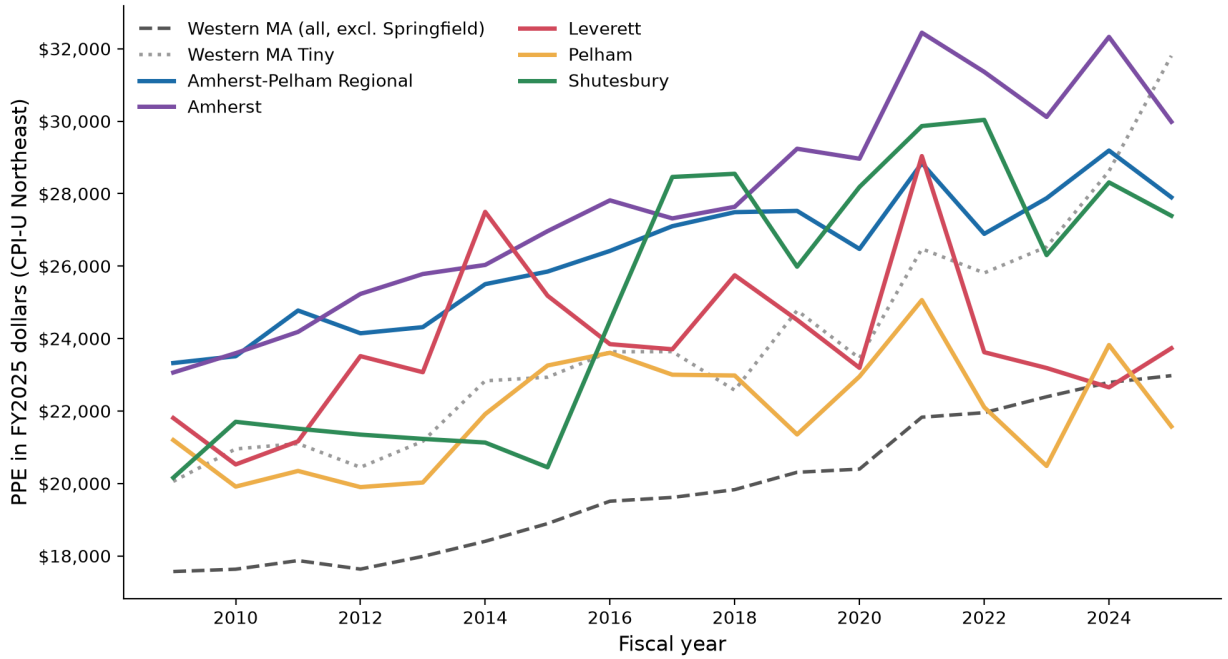


Figure 2. PPE in constant FY2025 dollars (CPI-U Northeast), ARPS districts and Western MA averages.

Notes and open questions

This draft covers PPE only. Chapter 70 aid and net school spending can be restated the same way. The main report's original CPI file used calendar-year averages; this addendum uses fiscal-year averages, which match the school year. Inflation series: BLS CUUR0100SA0 and CUUR0000SA0 (monthly), BEA A829RD (quarterly), retrieved October 18, 2026.